

tries such as the UK will continue, although the UK is a close ally of Canada and part of the Five Eyes intelligence alliance. Until now, the free trade agreement (FTA) talks between the UK and India remain unaffected. Britain's Business and Trade Secretary Kemi Badenoch recently said the two countries are very close to achieving a mutually beneficial FTA.

Economists agree that given the strong economic relationship and people to people connect between India and Canada, trade ties between them are unlikely to be disrupted. Nagesh Kumar, Director of Institute for Studies in Industrial Development, points out that trade is driven by mutuality of demand and supply, despite the hiccups caused by some issues in the past related to Sikh extremists. "This is perhaps the first time that India-Canada relations have sunk to such a low. I expect ongoing trade to not be affected significantly unless something more serious happens," he says.

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However, he notes that the pause in the trade talks is likely to have some impact on overall sentiment as businesses might choose to be more cautious about any future expansion plans.

Trade policy specialist Samridhi Bimal also points out that the recent developments are worrisome, but they are unlikely to have a significant impact on economic relations. "Khalistan has been a long-standing issue but it has not impacted trade between the two countries until now. The pause in trade negotiations is a temporary hiccup and should not be seen as a full stop. The two countries share strong economic ties, which should work as an incentive for them to work on a peaceful resolution," she says.

Clearly, breaking off trade ties will be in neither country's interest, but how soon a speedy resolution materialises will be crucial in the backdrop of the global slowdown and the ongoing war in Ukraine that has already dampened the economic outlook for most countries. **BT**

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START-UPS

The Revolving Door

Several senior executives and business heads bid adieu to start-up unicorns in the first half of 2023

BY BHAVYA KAUSHAL

► **INDIAN START-UPS SEEM** to have hit refresh. From focussing on profitability to taking more cognizance of compliance and corporate governance, a lot has been happening. However, this transition appears to have also sparked a churn among the top brass at some start-ups, as many executives have decided to put in their papers to either start their own businesses or join legacy firms.

According to a report shared by Longhouse Consulting, Indian e-commerce start-up Meesho and edtech major Byju's have seen the highest number of exits by far, followed by Bhavish Aggarwal-led Ola. Unicorn start-ups such as Unacademy and Swiggy, which claimed to have hit the profitability benchmark this year, also witnessed some senior-level exits. Dale Vaz, former Chief Technology Officer, left Swiggy to launch his wealth tech start-up, Aaritya.

In the first half of this year, more than 20 senior executives have bid adieu to start-up unicorns.

Founded in 2015 by Vidit Aatrey and Sanjeev Barnwal, Meesho enables small businesses to sell their products online. It has raised several rounds of investments from the likes of SoftBank. But as the company grappled with the funding winter in 2023, top executives such as Prateek Agarwal (Vice President and GM of Monetisation), Shikhar Saxena (Group Product Manager), Mayur Borsaikia (Associate Director), Anupam Yash Vardhan (Group Product Manager) and Sruthi Sivakumar (Vice President of Design) have left the company to either start their own companies or join other start-